covert communications proved effective. Despite his public defiance, Berlusconi privately engaged with the IMF on issues such as fiscal policy, tax reforms, and structural adjustments. Between 2010 and 2012, Italy's executive director (ED) at the IMF submitted 202 pre-meeting statements, the highest number of any country during that period, underscoring the depth of behind-the-scenes engagement.[3] A word cloud of these statements (figure 6.1) reveals the breadth of topics discussed, ranging from fiscal consolidation to economic stability.